Lithuanian ablaut is span-conditioned allomorphy: a case against readjustment

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Treating phonological changes in the root via a special mechanism (readjustment rules) cannot capture Lithuanian root patterns.

Takeaways

- Some phonological changes happen in a specific morphosyntactic environment
  English past tense: *give – gave, come – came, …*
- An approach dating back to the Sound Pattern of English (Chomsky & Halle 1968) and attributed to Distributed Morphology: (Halle & Marantz 1993)

(1) *Readjustment rule*
Nucleus(Y) → /eɪ/ / __ PAST , where Y = {give, come, …}
↑ applies to a root ↑ in a morphosyntactic context

- Rules of this format are unable to capture the Lithuanian pattern of morphosyntactically-conditioned root phonology
- But a small change in rule format makes all the difference: VI mappings don't have the same problem

(2) *Vocabulary Insertion*
PAST ↔ [F] / __ {give, come …}
↑ a morphosyntactic feature ↑ in the context of a root

0. Vowels in the Lithuanian verb

- Lithuanian roots show vowel changes (= ablaut)

Ablaut in three environments.

šɪl-ti šɪl-o šɪl-s	'warm-INF' 'warm-3.PAST' 'warm-FUT'	ši:l-a	'warm-3.**PRES**'	length
gɪn-ti gɪn-a gɪn-s	'defend-INF' 'defend-3.PRES' 'defend-FUT'	gi:n-e	'defend-3.**PAST**'	length
lɪnk-ti	'get bent' (= bend.INCH)	lenk-ti	'bend' (= bend.**CAUSATIVE**)	height

- The same root participates in several of these: 4 forms total for 'rise'

	'rise'	'rise.**CAUSATIVE**'
Present	ki:l	kel
Past	kɪl	ke:l
Future	kɪl	kel

Generalizations:
(i) For a set of roots, a tense feature (PAST / PRESENT) is associated with a long vowel in the root.
(ii) For a set of roots, a causative form is associated with a lower vowel than an inchoative form.

1. Readjustment fails to generate the pattern

- A more complex pattern (Lithuanian) runs into several problems

(3) Readjustment rules that capture the generalization
Nucleus(Y1) → [+long] / __ PRESENT, where Y1 = {rise, warm, …}
Nucleus(Y2) → [+long] / __ PAST, where Y2 = {rise, defend, …}
Nucleus(Y3) → [–high] / __ CAUS, where Y3 = {rise, bend, …}

√rise lengthens in the present

√rise lengthens in the past

	'rise'	'rise.**CAUSATIVE**'
Present	ki:l	ke:l ☹
Past	ki:l ☹	ke:l
Future	kɪl	kel

- PAST/PRESENT lengthens, CAUS lowers. ✓Generalization captured

! This **overgenerates.** (see table above)

(4) Readjustment fix: enriched context
Nucleus(Y2) → [+long] / __ **PAST, CAUS** where Y1 = {rise, …}

! (4) still **overgenerates**: CAUS doesn't block PRES-ablaut. (see table below)

Possible fixes:

- Nucleus(Y1) → [+long] / __ **PRES, INCH** is unorthodox syntactically (if INCH is 'unmarked')
- Locality condition: CAUS intervenes between √rise and PRESENT? No: √rise-PAST interaction happens even over CAUS

	'rise'	'rise.**CAUSATIVE**'
Present	ki:l	ke:l ☹
Past	kɪl	ke:l
Future	kɪl	kel

√rise still lengthens in the present

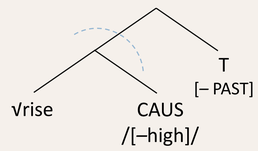
! (4) **misses the generalization:** lengthening is associated with tense, and has nothing to do with the causative; but in (4), they are equal triggers

! (4) is **redundant**: we still need the PAST-only rule (2) for 'defend': non-CAUS roots that still undergo past-tense lengthening

Readjustment rules (structural description = root) cannot capture the Lithuanian pattern where **a single root** has 4 phonological forms.

2. Vocabulary Insertion of [F]

- No problems if PAST, PRESENT, CAUSATIVE are insertion targets rather than contexts
  - Crucial trick: the context can be a **span** (Merchant 2015, Svenonius 2012) (compare (3) & (5))
  - Then all we need is a locality assumption for VI



  - CAUS is phasal, √rise-T interaction for allomorphy impossible if CAUS is not null (Embick 2010)
  - cf. English *raise – raised (*rose)*
  - Floating [–high] intervenes – prohibits pruning

(5) Vocabulary Insertion
PRESENT ↔ [+long] / __ {rise, warm, …}
PAST ↔ [+long] / __ {{rise, CAUS}, defend, …}
CAUS ↔ [–high] / __ {rise, bend, …}

{√rise, CAUS} is the relevant piece

√rise-PRES are non-local: regular(ish) assumption for VI

{√rise, CAUS} is the relevant piece: local to tense

	'rise'	'rise.**CAUSATIVE**'
Present	ki:l	kel
Past	kɪl	ke:l
Future	kɪl	kel

✓ Captures the generalization that PAST is associated with [+long], CAUSATIVE with [–high]

The pattern is easily captured when:
- the target of phonological insertion is the syntactic feature,
- the context can include spans

- But once we know that a root is ablauting, the type of ablaut is phonologically predictable:
  - Non-low vowels lengthen, low vowels raise
  - The output is always [+long, –low]
- Unified under one VI rule:

(5) PAST ↔ { [+long], [–low] } / __ {{rise, CAUS}, defend, hang, …}

- Both floating features dock: one is vacuous (machinery inspired by Wolf 2007)
  - –low remains –low, becomes +long
  - +low becomes –low, remains +long

Both floating features dock: lengthening.

	gɪn + [+long]$_3$ [–low]$_4$	MAXFLT	IDENT
	[–long$_1$, –low$_2$]		
☞ a.	gi:n [+long$_3$, –low$_4$]		**
b.	gi:n [+long$_3$, –low$_2$]	*!	*
c.	gɪn [–long$_1$, –low$_2$]	**!	*

Both floating features dock: raising.

	kɑ:r + [+long]$_3$ [–low]$_4$	MAXFLT	IDENT
	[+long$_1$, +low$_2$]		
☞ a.	ko:r [+long$_3$, –low$_4$]		**
b.	ko:r [+long$_3$, –low$_4$]	*!	*
c.	kɑ:r [+long$_1$, +low$_2$]	**!	*

3. Bonus: two types of ablaut

- PAST-tense ablaut has two types: some roots lengthen, some raise
- We need to list which roots the ablaut applies to (=lexical index): not phonologically general

ablauting			*non-ablauting*		
root	*PAST*	*gloss*	*root*	*PAST*	*gloss*
vem	ve:m	'vomit'	tem	tem	'darken'
gɪn	gi:n	'defend'	gɪn	gɪn	'shepherd'
kɑu	ko:v	'fight'	kɑu	kɑv	'go'

root	*PAST*	*gloss*	*count*
lengthening ablaut			
kel	ke:l	'raise'	23
gɪn	gi:n	'defend'	36
kul	ku:l	'whack'	26
raising ablaut			
ʃɑu	ʃo:v	'shoot'	15
kɑ:r	ko:r	'hang'	1

Conclusions

- A case of apparent morphosyntactically-conditioned phonological changes (vowel alternations in Lithuanian verbal roots) is actually better captured as allomorphy
- A minimally different phonological approach (readjustment rules) is in principle unable to capture these data due to the format of the rule

Sel. refs.: Chomsky, N. & Halle, M. 1968. *The Sound Pattern of English.* Embick, D. 2010. *Localism versus globalism in morphology and phonology*. MIT Press. Halle, M. & Marantz, A. 1993. Distributed Morphology and the Pieces of Inflection. In *The View from Building 20*. MIT Press. Merchant, J. 2015. How much context is enough? Two cases of span-conditioned stem allomorphy. *Linguistic Inquiry*. Svenonius, P. 2012. Spanning. Ms., University of Tromsø. Wolf, M. 2007. For an autosegmental theory of mutation. In *UMOP 32.*